

Ngöndro

Level

1



A Guide to Ngöndro

The Six Thoughts & Refuge and Bodhichitta

~ Table of Contents ~

<u>Practice Checklist</u>	4
Before Beginning this Level	4
Preparing to Begin	4
Completing the Level	4
<u>Introduction</u>	5
Before You Begin	5
<u>Practice Structure</u>	6
How to Structure a Session of Practice	6
Sample 90-Minutes Practice Session	6
How to Structure Multiple Sessions in a Day	6
<u>Topics for Contemplation</u>	8
<u>Practice Instructions</u>	10
Opening the Session	10
General Practice Instructions	10
<u>Instructions for Contemplating the Six Thoughts</u>	12
Precious Human Life	12
Impermanence	13
Karma	14
Suffering of Samsara	15
<u>Instructions for Practicing Refuge</u>	16
<u>Instructions for Contemplating Bodhichitta</u>	18
<u>Instructions for Meditating on Stillness, Movement, and Awareness</u>	21
<u>Instructions on Pointing Out that All Phenomena Come from Mind</u>	23
<u>Optional Readings</u>	26
<u>Sample Retreat Schedules</u>	28
<u>Contact Us</u>	29

~ Practice Checklist ~

Before Beginning this Level

- ☑ Take refuge with a Tergar lama or in another Buddhist lineage
- ☑ Attend *Path of Liberation Levels 1 and 2* at one of Tergar's Path of Liberation retreats

Preparing to Begin

- ☑ Subscribe to Vajrayana Online and enroll in the ngöndro course¹²
- ☑ Get the ngöndro practice liturgy (*The Perfectly Clear Path to Liberation*)
- ☑ Get a mala (rosary) or counter
- ☑ Read the instructions in this guide

Completing the Level

- ☑ Complete 50 hours of contemplation of the six thoughts
- ☑ Complete 50 hours of contemplation of bodhichitta
- ☑ Complete 50 hours of nature of mind practice
- ☑ Complete 27,777 prostrations³
- ☑ Spend four days in retreat (with 6+ hours of ngöndro practice each day)⁴

¹ The Path of Liberation guides are developed with all Tergar students in mind, but are specifically for those students following the courses in Vajrayana Online. Having received the essential instructions during a Path of Liberation retreat, students can choose to enroll in level specific courses on Nectar of the Path and/or ngöndro in Vajrayana Online or practice on their own with the support of the guides for each level of practice.

² Vajrayana Online is an ongoing, subscription-based program. We are committed to making these teachings available to people at all financial levels, so if you have financial issues that make it difficult to pay the recommended rate, please inquire and we will work with you to find a solution.

³ It is also permissible to complete the entire accumulation of 111,111 prostrations in this first level.

⁴ **Note:** Days of retreat are cumulative and need not be practiced in succession. Retreat hours and accumulations count toward the practice requirements for this level.

~ Introduction ~

Before You Begin

Receiving the full lineage transmission is an essential prerequisite to practicing the ngöndro track of the Path of Liberation. The opportunity to take refuge, to receive the reading transmission and brief instructions on ngöndro, to participate in an empowerment, and to receive pointing out instructions on the nature of mind are offered at Tergar's Path of Liberation retreats. These elements comprise the required transmissions to begin the ngöndro track of the Path of Liberation path as practiced in the Tergar community.⁵

Once you have received these transmissions and are ready to begin, we recommend that you follow along with the ngöndro course in Vajrayana Online. The instructions included in this course will guide you step-by-step through each level of practice. If you choose to practice without the support of the course, you can simply follow the instructions in this guide to inform your daily practice.

⁵ When attending Path of Liberation Levels 1 and 2 at one of Tergar's Path of Liberation retreats, you will receive the full transmission and permission to practice the 4 x 111,111 ngöndro.

~ Practice Structure ~

How to Structure a Session of Practice

In this level, every session of practice will involve four elements: reciting the liturgy and any additional opening or closing chants, alternating between periods of contemplation and resting in awareness, accumulating prostrations and reciting the refuge prayer, and nature of mind practice. Within this general structure, you can be flexible and spend more time on resting meditation some days and more time contemplating on others. In each session, however, you should try to spend some time contemplating, some resting, some doing prostrations, and some practicing the nature of mind instructions. If your daily practice includes 100 prostrations, at least twenty minutes of contemplation/resting meditation, and at least 10 minutes of nature of mind practice, you would complete the requirements for this level in less than one year.⁶ The following provides a suggested guideline for a session of practice. Detailed instructions are found in the following section.

Sample 90-Minutes Practice Session

- 15 minutes ~ Opening chants and ngöndro liturgy
- 20 minutes ~ Contemplating daily topic and resting in awareness (alternating)
- 40 minutes ~ Prostrations while reciting refuge prayer
- 10 minutes ~ Nature of mind meditation
- 5 minutes ~ Dedication prayers and closing chants

How to Structure Multiple Sessions in a Day

If you are doing multiple sessions in a single day, individual sessions can be as long as your schedule allows. If you are in retreat, four longer sessions of one to three hours often works well. If you prefer shorter sessions, a six-session schedule is another option. The important thing is to find what works for you.⁷

⁶ It is also permissible to complete the entire accumulation of 111,111 prostrations in this first level. In this case, you would complete the accumulation of prostrations in roughly one year if your daily practice includes 300 prostrations.

⁷ Sample retreat schedules are included at the end of this guide.

At this stage of practice, when you practice multiple sessions in a single day, each session will be roughly the same. You only need to do the nine-fold breath and shaking HA in the first session, but aside from that, you can chant the opening prayers, the ngöndro liturgy for the six thoughts, refuge and bodhichitta, the dedication, and any other concluding prayers in every session.

~ Topics for Contemplation ~

The topics that you will contemplate during the first level of ngöndro are broken into three main categories: the six thoughts, bodhichitta, and nature of mind practice. Nature of mind practice at this level consists of exploring stillness, movement, and awareness and the first pointing out instruction that all phenomena come from mind. What follows presents the individual topics and a suggestion for how many hours you should devote to each topic.⁸ The time requirement for each contemplation includes the entire meditation session. Thus, if you complete fifty one-hour sessions that include contemplating the six thoughts, prostrations, chanting the liturgy, and nature of mind practice, you will meet the requirement for that part of this level.

Phase 1:

The Six Thoughts (50 hours) + Stillness, Movement, and Awareness (25 hours)⁹

- 8.5 hours on the beginningless suffering of samsara
- 8.5 hours on the precious human life
- 8.5 hours on impermanence
- 8.5 hours on karma
- 8.5 hours on the suffering of samsara
- 8.5 hours on the benefits of liberation

Phase 2:

Bodhichitta (50 hours) + The First Pointing Out Instruction (25 hours)

- 10 hours on loving kindness and compassion (step 1)
- 10 hours on immeasurable love and compassion (step 2)
 - Loved one
 - Neutral person
 - Difficult person

⁸ Detailed instructions are included in the next section.

⁹ Each session should include some contemplation and some nature of mind practice. For example, in a one hour session, you might spend twenty minutes contemplating impermanence during the four thoughts section of the liturgy and ten minutes doing nature of mind practice later in the session after dissolving the refuge visualization.

- Oneself
 - All beings
- 10 hours on aspiration bodhichitta (step 3)
- 10 hours application bodhichitta (step 4)
- 10 hours on absolute bodhichitta (step 5)

~ *Practice Instructions* ~

Notes on *The Perfectly Clear Path to Liberation*

In this level, the practices of contemplating the six thoughts and bodhichitta, taking refuge and offering prostrations, and resting in the nature of mind will be the focal point of your sessions. Nature of mind practice at this stage relates to an exploration of stillness, movement, and awareness and the first pointing out instruction that introduces that all phenomena come from mind. The following outline provides a rough framework for each session. Detailed instructions can be found in the ngöndro course in Vajrayana Online.

Opening the Session

- Begin by taking a few moments to check in with your posture, then pause for a while to let your mind open and relax, and rest for a minute or two in open awareness.
- Next, arouse bodhichitta, thinking to yourself, "I am now going to practice ngöndro in order to become buddha, so that I can help all beings recognize their true nature and become buddhas." As you do so, chant the Refuge and Bodhichitta prayer contained in the daily chants, followed by the Four Immeasurables. If you have time, you may also chant the Seven Line Prayer to Guru Rinpoche and any other prayers or sutras that you find inspiring.¹⁰
- Perform the nine-fold breathing exercise (if you have received the transmission to do so).¹¹

General Practice Instructions

- As you chant the lines on the six thoughts, chant slowly and briefly pause after each set of lines to contemplate the topic presented. When you reach the line that pertains to the main topic you are contemplating, pause for a longer period and

¹⁰ For these and all other recitations, you may chant in Tibetan, English, or both. If you chant in both, chant each section one time in Tibetan and then one time in English. When a stanza is to be chanted three times, chant the first two times in Tibetan and the final time in English. Please note: the italicized text in the liturgy does not need to be chanted and is purely for instructional purposes.

¹¹ For those who have received the transmission of the nine-fold breath, an instructional video to refresh your memory is included in Vajrayana Online.

commence your daily contemplation, alternating periods of contemplation and resting in awareness.¹²

- When you are finished contemplating, continue with the liturgy, chanting the refuge verses beginning on page 8. As you chant the first part of the liturgy on refuge beginning with “In the sky before me, in an expanse...” try to sense the presence of the sources of refuge. It is not important to be able to imagine this very clearly. The most important point is to feel as though you are in their presence.
- Next, place your hands in *anjali* (prayer mudra) and chant the long refuge prayer on pages 9–12 three times, beginning with, “NAMO / Sentient beings, all of whom have been my mothers...”
- Following this step, stand and offer prostrations while reciting the five-line refuge prayer on page 12, beginning with, “OM AH HUNG / In you, assembly of the three kayas...”¹³
- When you are done offering prostrations, recite the rest of the refuge liturgy from pages 13-16. Dissolve the visualization by chanting the line on page 16, “The objects of refuge dissolve into me”. Begin by letting all the objects of refuge dissolve into Padmasambhava. Padmasambhava then melts into light and dissolves into you. Having merged your own mind inseparably with the enlightened minds of the guru and the sources of refuge, rest in awareness.
- Once you have completed the verses on refuge, recite the section on bodhicitta on pages 17-21. If you have completed the requirement for contemplating the six thoughts and are now contemplating bodhichitta, you can pause here and alternate periods of contemplation with periods of resting in awareness.¹⁴ If you have not yet completed fifty hours of contemplating the six thoughts, pause here briefly and contemplate bodhichitta before continuing.

¹² Detailed instructions on contemplating the six thoughts are presented in the following section.

¹³ The refuge prayer does not need to be coordinated with the prostrations. For example, you could say the six line prayer once while doing two prostrations. For the accumulations in this practice, you should count the number of prostrations, not the number of refuge prayers. Detailed instructions on taking refuge are presented in the following section.

¹⁴ Detailed instructions on arousing bodhichitta are presented in the following section.

- After reciting the liturgy for bodhichitta and the four immeasurables, dissolve the visualization by letting all the objects of refuge dissolve into Guru Padmasambhava. Padmasambhava then melts into light and dissolves into you. Having merged your own mind inseparably with the enlightened minds of the guru and the sources of refuge, rest in awareness.
- Next, pause for a period of nature of mind practice.¹⁵
- Following nature of mind practice, perform the "shaking HA" exercise (if you have received the transmission to do so).
- Skipping Vajrasattva, mandala, and guru yoga, with hands in anjali, conclude by reciting the dedication liturgy on pages 55-58, followed by any other dedications, aspirations, long-life prayers, etc. Imagine that you dedicate whatever good comes from your practice to the awakening of all beings.
- When you are done chanting, relax and rest in awareness.

Instructions for Contemplating the Six Thoughts¹⁶

The Beginningless Suffering of Samsara

- Chant the first six lines of the liturgy on page 3, beginning with, "Alas! How sad! From my past lives..."
- **The first step** is to contemplate the events and activities in your life that have ultimately been unsatisfactory. Remember the different activities and possessions you have pursued and consider whether they have brought you any lasting happiness. You have sought happiness and pleasure in this and countless previous lifetimes, and yet never have you found it. Contemplate that as long as you continue in samsara, you will never find true and lasting happiness.
- **The second step** is to recognize that there is a path that leads to lasting happiness. This path has been followed by countless others before you, including the Buddhas, bodhisattvas, the masters of the lineage, and your own teachers. By practicing the

¹⁵ Detailed instructions on nature of mind practice are presented in the following section.

¹⁶ Practice these six thoughts in succession, making each the focal point of your practice together with the accompanying nature of mind practice before moving on to the next set of instructions.

dharma, you are embarking on the true path to freedom. Contemplate and appreciate the fact that you have this rare opportunity to pursue a meaningful path.

- **The third step** is to pray to the three Jewels to bless you as you embark upon this path. Contemplate the kindness of the Buddha, who turned the wheel of Dharma and taught this unerring path towards happiness. Consider the power of the Dharma, and appreciate the countless teachings contained in it that lead to liberation. Finally, consider the various men and women who have practiced on this path before you and attained lasting freedom from suffering. Pray to the Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha to bless you as you embark on this profound path of practice.
- Throughout this reflection, alternate periods of contemplation with periods of resting in awareness.

*Precious Human Life*¹⁷

- Chant the first two lines of the liturgy on page 5, beginning with, “I begin by meditating on the precious freedoms and riches.”
- **The first step** is to try to see the freedoms and opportunities that you already have in your own life. Appreciate the fact that you are alive and have this human body together with the senses. Appreciate that you have eyes to see with, ears to hear with, a tongue that makes it possible for you to taste food and drink, a nose that you can smell fragrances with, and that you are able to touch and feel tactile sensations. Appreciate that you can breathe and move around. Most of the time, we take these basic attributes for granted and do not appreciate them. The practice here is to appreciate what you already have and recognize these wonderful qualities. Reflect on these different attributes one-by-one.
- **Step two** is to appreciate everything good that has happened and is happening in your life. Appreciate that you have friends, family, a wonderful teacher, a profound practice, and a supportive spiritual community. You have human intelligence, knowledge, love, compassion, wisdom, and other skills and talents.

¹⁷ In any given practice session, you can focus on one of these steps, or you can alternate between steps. Feel free to experiment and find the approach that works best for you.

- **Step three** is to exchange your own situation with that of other beings in different places and realms. Try to see that what you take for granted is extremely rare in other places. An animal, for example, does not have the same mental capacity and opportunity to practice the dharma.
- Throughout this reflection, alternate periods of contemplation with periods of resting in awareness.

Impermanence¹⁸

- Once you have completed roughly one sixth of the practice hours with the previous contemplation, you may move on to the contemplation of impermanence, and spend only a short period contemplating the precious human life.
- Chant the five lines of the liturgy on impermanence on pages 4-5, beginning with, “With each passing day, month, and year...”
- **Step one** is to reflect on the subtle momentary impermanence of your own body. Notice the change that happens with each breath. You breathe in, and the previous moment is gone. You breathe out and everything has changed. Nothing stays the same, even for a moment. Every heartbeat indicates change. Every time your heart beats, the whole universe has changed. Notice all of these changes as you alternate periods of contemplation and resting in awareness.
- **Step two** is to contemplate the more obvious level of impermanence. Reflect upon something that has happened in the past. It might have been something good or something bad. If it was something bad that happened, look at the result that came out of that. The event may have been painful and you suffered, but perhaps a good result came out of it. On the other hand, if there was something positive that happened, it might now be gone or it might have turned into an unfortunate circumstance. It is very important to see that your life goes up and down and that life is very colorful for that exact reason. Alternate this contemplation with resting in awareness.

¹⁸ In any given practice session, you can focus on one of these steps, or you can alternate between steps. Feel free to experiment and find the approach that works best for you.

- **Step three** is to contemplate that you are getting older and eventually will die. Try to see that moment-by-moment, second-by-second, you are getting older. Recognize the fleeting nature of this life and resolve to make the most of the time you have. Contemplate how you can focus on what is truly meaningful and of lasting benefit.
- Alternate this contemplation with periods of resting in awareness.

*Karma*¹⁹

- Once you have completed roughly one sixth of the practice hours contemplating the previous topic, you may move on to the contemplation of karma, and spend only a short period contemplating the beginningless suffering of samsara, precious human life and impermanence.
- Chant the next five lines of the liturgy on page 5, beginning with, “Happiness comes from virtue and suffering from misdeeds...”
- **Step one** is to contemplate interdependence. Begin by reflecting on how everything — the universe, the environment, your behavior, and your mind — is related. Our inner experience is shaped by what happens around us and what happens in our own body and mind. Contemplate this and alternate with periods of resting in awareness.
- **Step two** is to try to go deeper into interdependence. Take a specific aspect of your experience — such as the body, an emotion, or any other experience — and notice how it consists of many different elements. Notice all the different causes and conditions that have come together for it to occur. In recognizing that everything we experience consists of many different parts and is the result of many causes and conditions, notice how things are not nearly as solid and real as they often appear. Alternate this investigation with periods of resting in awareness.
- **Step three** is to contemplate how this understanding relates to your behavior and actions. As your understanding of karma and interdependence deepens, you will see that your future experience is shaped by what you do in the present. Consider your

¹⁹ In any given practice session, you can focus on one of these steps, or you can alternate between steps. Feel free to experiment and find the approach that works best for you.

own actions and empower yourself by knowing that you are in charge over your future situation.

- Rest in awareness from time to time, alternating contemplation with periods of resting in awareness.

*Suffering of Samsara*²⁰

- Once you have completed roughly one sixth of the practice hours contemplating the previous topic, you may move on to the contemplation of the suffering of samsara, and spend only a short period contemplating the beginningless suffering of samsara, precious human life, impermanence, and karma.
- Chant the six lines of the liturgy on page 7, beginning with, “No matter where I am born in the six realms...”
- **Step one** is to contemplate the suffering of suffering. Begin by contemplating all the inevitable things that we try to avoid. We want to stay healthy and young, and we do not want to die, but all of these will eventually happen. Reflect on how you cannot avoid these things and how they are a source of suffering. From time to time, rest in awareness before continuing your contemplation.
- **Step two** is to contemplate the suffering of change. Think of a situation or a person that makes you happy. Try to see how this feeling of happiness comes with strong expectations and grasping. Notice how we want things to remain the way they are now, or we expect them to turn out a particular way. Since everything changes, these expectations and attachments to the situation or person will lead you to experience the suffering of change. Contemplate this as you rest in awareness from time to time.
- **Step three** is to contemplate pervasive suffering. Reflect on everything that you have that makes you happy: your job, house, partner, etc. Although you have all these things, if you look deeply, is there still a feeling that things could be better, that your life is still incomplete? Alternate this contemplation with resting in awareness.

²⁰ In any given practice session, you can focus on one of these steps, or you can alternate between steps. Feel free to experiment and find the approach that works best for you.

- **Step four** is to develop renunciation. Recognizing that everything changes and that our expectations rarely match what actually happens, consider that no matter where you look for happiness within samsara, there is no lasting happiness to be found. As your understanding of the suffering of samsara deepens, try to connect with this feeling of wanting to be free of samsara and to achieve lasting happiness by discovering your own true nature.
- **Step five** is to develop love and compassion. Understand from your own feelings of wanting to be free of suffering and to achieve happiness, that this is also true for others, for all sentient beings. Make the wish that everyone be free of suffering and the causes of suffering, and that they achieve happiness and the causes of happiness. You may recite silently, “May you be happy and have the causes of happiness,” and “May you be free of suffering and the causes of suffering.”
- Alternate this contemplation with periods of resting in awareness.

The Benefits of Liberation

- Chant the six lines of the liturgy on page 6, starting with “Perfecting the two accumulations...”
- **Step one** is to contemplate the fully awakened state. Consider what it would be like to be free from all forms of suffering, to dwell in lasting happiness, and to be the very embodiment of awareness, compassion, and wisdom. Use your imagination to experience how your perception of reality might shift as a fully awakened being.
- **Step two** is to remember that your liberation will benefit other beings as well as yourself. When you become awakened, you will have the capacity to help countless beings on their own journey to enlightenment. Consider the multitude of beings that suffer in samsara, and imagine what it will be like to help them recognize the buddha within so that they can relieve themselves of their suffering.
- **Step three** is to appreciate the many tools the lineage has given you to help you on your journey towards liberation. You have received the profound instructions of this ngöndro from a lineage holder, and through practicing it you will accomplish the two

accumulations of merit and wisdom, which will ultimately lead to you becoming fully awake. Take a moment to appreciate this profound path and the lineage.

- Alternate this contemplation with periods of resting in awareness.

Instructions for Practicing Refuge²¹

- Chant the refuge liturgy beginning on page 8 with the line, “In the sky before me, in an expanse of rainbow-hued clouds...”
- **The first step** is to reflect upon your motivation for taking refuge. Think to yourself, “I want to take refuge not only to benefit myself, but to also benefit my friends, family, and all sentient beings. I am going to practice refuge to become a buddha in order to help all sentient beings become buddhas.”
- **Step two** is to imagine the refuge tree and the sources of refuge. Begin by imagining that you are in a beautiful environment surrounded by trees, flowers, birds, green fields, etc. Within this atmosphere, imagine a wish-fulfilling tree, consisting of a trunk and four branches, one in each direction. Imagine that in the middle of the wish-fulfilling tree is a lotus flower. Upon the lotus flower sits Guru Padmasambhava, who looks upon you with great affection. He is seated in the vajra posture with legs interlocked, adorned with ornaments and garments. In his right hand is a vajra, and in his left a begging bowl. A katvanga (trident) is leaning in the crook of his left arm. Imagine Guru Padmasambhava as though he is a mirage or like a reflection of the moon in a lake, as an empty appearance that is not solid or real. You can also think of Guru Padmasambhava as representing all the buddhas and bodhisattvas and your own teachers. On the branches around Padmasambhava sit the rest of the sources of refuge on their own branches: to Padmasambhava’s right are all the buddhas, behind is the dharma, represented by dharma texts, to his left the noble sangha of arhats and bodhisattvas, below him are Dorje Drolö and the yidam deities, and below Dorje Drolö are the dharma protectors. Above Padmasambhava sits Samanthabhadra and the five Buddha Families. The most important part of this

²¹ These five steps are the most important elements of the practice of taking refuge. All of these elements should be included in each practice session, but you can choose to spend more time on a specific element in a particular session if you find it helpful for your practice.

practice is to feel the presence of Padmasambhava, who embodies your gurus and the buddhas throughout the three times, so do not worry if you cannot maintain a clear visual image.

- **Step three** is to reflect on the enlightened qualities of your guru, who is inseparable from Padmasambhava. Begin by bringing about a strong feeling of Padmasambhava being present in front of you. Reflect on all the enlightened qualities of Padmasambhava, such as wisdom, compassion, and loving-kindness. Imagine that you can actually feel these enlightened qualities radiating from him. You are taking refuge in Padmasambhava's wisdom and compassion. As you reflect upon these qualities, rest in awareness from time to time.
- **Step four** is to reflect upon the meaning of refuge while reciting the five-line refuge prayer and doing prostrations.²² Begin by getting up from your seat and place your hands in anjali at your heart-center. As you recite the refuge prayer beginning with, "OM AH HUNG / In you, assembly of the three kayas..." bring your hands to the forehead, throat, and heart-center, and then perform a prostration. As you recite the refuge verses, continue this sequence.²³ While doing prostrations with your body and reciting the refuge prayer with your speech, reflect upon the meaning of taking refuge with your mind. The meaning of taking refuge is acceptance. You accept the Buddha as your guide and teacher, the Dharma as your path and practice, and the Sangha as your friends and companions on the path.
- **Step five** is to contemplate the inner refuge. Chant the verses on pages 13–16, ending with, "Become as pure as a cloudless sky". Next, connect with the buddha nature within yourself by imagining that Padmasambhava melts into light and that this light dissolves into you. Imagine that your mind and the enlightened awareness of Padmasambhava merge inseparably, like water poured into water. Following this,

²² If you are not able to perform full prostrations, try to perform an easier version. If you are not able to perform any form of physical prostrations remain seated and focus on the meaning of refuge as you recite the refuge verses with your hands in anjali.

²³ The number of prostrations you do depends on how much time you have. To meet the requirement for this level, at a minimum, offer 108 prostrations each session. The number of prostrations does not need to match the number of refuge verse recitations. You should count prostrations, not recitations.✿

simply rest within awareness itself. From time to time, remind yourself that your buddha nature is not different from the awakened nature of all the buddhas. Then simply rest in awareness once again.

Instructions for Contemplating Bodhichitta²⁴

- Chant the bodhichitta liturgy beginning on page 17 with the line, “NAMO / Think of me, Three Jewels...”
- **The first step** is to recognize the feeling within yourself of wanting to be happy and to be free of pain and suffering. Try to connect with this feeling and see how everything you do is an expression of these two desires. For example, every time you blink, you do so to achieve a little bit of happiness and to avoid the suffering that follows from not blinking. The same is true for mundane things like changing your posture, eating, and going to work or spending time with your friends, and also more profound pursuits like meditating or reading spiritual teachings. Reflect on all the many things you do in your life and how they reflect the basic desires to be happy and to be free from suffering. Alternate this contemplation with periods of resting in awareness.
- **Step two** is to extend this feeling of wanting to be happy and to be free of suffering to others. Noticing this deep-rooted wish in yourself, recognize that this is true for all other beings as well.
 - **Loved one:** Begin this practice with someone close to you, someone you like. Recognize that just as you wish to be happy and free of suffering, so does this loved one. Think of this person and recite silently in your mind, “May you have happiness and the causes of happiness,” and “May you be free from suffering and the causes of suffering.” Respectively, these phrases represent loving-kindness and compassion. You can work with these two phrases separately or together, repeating them as long as you like. Rest in awareness from time to time and then again recite these two phrases silently in your mind. Before moving on, rest in awareness for a few moments.

²⁴ Practice these steps in succession, making each the focal point of your practice for a number of sessions before moving on to the next set of instructions.

- **Neutral person:** Next, follow the instructions above, but this time, practice with a so-called “neutral person.” It can be the mailman, the cashier at a gas station, or a person you see in the subway. The important point is that you choose a person for this practice that you neither particularly like nor dislike. As before, you can recite the phrases mentioned above after a short period of contemplation. When you are done, rest in awareness before continuing with your practice.
- **Difficult person:** For this step, choose a person that you find difficult or do not like. Try to recognize that this person’s behavior is rooted in wanting to be happy and free of suffering, although their behavior might lead to even more suffering for themselves and others. As before, you can recite the phrases mentioned above after a short period of contemplation. Alternate the contemplation and recitation with resting in awareness from time to time.
- **Yourself:** Now, do this practice for yourself. Recognize that just as others deserve to be happy and free from suffering, so do you. Recite silently in your mind, “May I have happiness and the causes of happiness,” and “May I be free from suffering and the causes of suffering.” Alternate this contemplation and recitation with resting in awareness.
- **All Beings:** The last step of this practice is to extend this wish to all beings. Recognize that the wish to be happy and free from suffering is not only true for human beings, but also for animals and other forms of life. Recite silently in your mind, “May all beings have happiness and the causes of happiness,” and “May all beings be free from suffering and the causes of suffering.” Alternate this wish with resting in awareness from time to time.
- After spending a number of sessions focused on the first two steps, you may proceed to contemplate aspiration and application bodhichitta, which takes place after the last line on page 20, which begins, “May they dwell in equanimity.”
- **Step three** is to contemplate aspiration bodhichitta. Begin by reflecting on how all of us want to be free from the endless cycle of suffering. The only way to achieve this

freedom is through attaining complete buddhahood. By doing so, you will also achieve unchangeable happiness. Wish that all sentient beings will achieve buddhahood, thinking, “I want to help all sentient beings recognize their buddha nature and become buddhas.” Alternate this contemplation with periods of resting in awareness.

- **Step four** is to contemplate application bodhichitta. Begin by contemplating the previous step of wishing that all beings attain buddhahood. Then, think to yourself, “For that reason, I am going to meditate and practice Dharma.” Try to extend this resolve to include both your formal meditation sessions and also everything you do during the day. For example, when you eat, you can think, “May I eat this food so that I can continue to practice meditation and become a buddha in order to help all beings become buddhas.” You can use a similar phrase with other activities during your day, like exercising, studying, sleeping, etc. Set a motivation that whatever you do will help you become a buddha in order to bring all sentient beings to buddhahood. Alternate this contemplation with resting in awareness.
- **Step Five** is to meditate on absolute bodhichitta. Begin by turning the mind inward. Reflect on how everything is impermanent, interdependent, and multiple. Then, try to go even deeper and see how impermanence, interdependence, and multiplicity are also concepts. The nature of reality is beyond both permanence and impermanence. It is totally beyond all concepts. When this insight dawns in you, simply let go of the reflection and rest in awareness for a few moments.

Instructions for Meditating on Stillness, Movement, and Awareness²⁵

- After dissolving the visualization and concluding your practice of refuge and bodhichitta, pause for a period of nature of mind practice. In this level, the first half of the nature of mind instructions pertain to the exploration of stillness, movement, and awareness.

²⁵ In any given practice session, you can focus on one of these steps, or you can alternate between steps. Feel free to experiment and find the approach that works best for you.

- For this practice, rest naturally without trying to control experience in any way, yet without being lost in distraction. When it comes to your state of mind, there are only two options: the mind is either still or it is moving. At times the mind may be calm, with few thoughts and emotions, or little movement of attention toward sense objects. At other times, it may be very active — thinking, feeling, and perceiving.
- **The first step** in this practice is to notice when the mind is still and when it is moving. You do not have to create or hold on to periods of stillness, or to stop the mind from being active by controlling thoughts and emotions, or directing your attention. The practice here is to rest in awareness no matter what state the mind is in — even if it is dull, restless, or confused. As long as you know that you are calm and peaceful, that you are restless and agitated, or that you are dull or confused, that is enough. Simply rest in awareness no matter what happens.
- **The second step** is to look at the nature of stillness and movement. Is the nature of stillness the same or different from the nature of movement? At this point, you can ask this question and directly observe your experience of stillness and movement. This is not a thought exercise. When the mind is still, what is the very nature of that stillness? Does it have a location? A shape or color? Does it have boundaries? When you explore the experience of stillness, what do you find? Do the same with the experience of movement and see if the nature of stillness and movement is the same or different.
- **For the third step**, turn your attention to awareness itself — to the one who is experiencing these expressions of stillness and movement. Is the knower of stillness the same or different from the knower of movement? Who or what is it that knows this stillness? What is it that experiences the mind's activity? Again, the point here is to explore your experience from within, not to answer with the conceptual mind.
- Throughout this exploration, the main practice is still to rest in awareness. You can intersperse periods of resting in awareness with a brief inquiry. For instance, you might begin by resting in awareness and noticing whether the mind is still or active. You could then gently inquire into the nature of the experience for a few moments,

and then again rest in awareness. After another short period of resting in awareness, you might then observe the knower, or experiencer, of movement or stillness for a few moments. Then relax and rest in awareness once again. In this way, you can alternate brief, gentle periods of inquiry with periods of resting naturally in awareness.

- End your nature of mind practice by resting in awareness.

Instructions on Pointing Out that All Phenomena Come from Mind²⁶

- The second half of the nature of mind instructions pertain to the exploration of the first pointing out instruction that all phenomena come from mind.
- For this practice, rest naturally without trying to control experience in any way, yet without being lost in distraction. This practice has two main components: analytical meditation (step 1–5) and resting meditation (step 6.)
- **The first step** is for the mind to look inward. Let the mind turn inward and look for the “Self” or “I.” We think of our body, speech, and mind — all together — as “me.” Ask yourself, “What is my body? What is my speech? What is my mind?” Observe your experience and see what you find. Alternate this inquiry with resting in awareness from time to time.
- **Step two** is to ask yourself, “Of my body, speech, and mind, which is the most important and shapes my experience the most? Which one is the boss? Does the body control the speech and mind? Does speech control the body and mind? Or does the mind control the body and speech?”
- **Step three** is to reflect on how the mind shapes our day-to-day experience. For example, you could recall an experience of being outside on a hot day and the aversion you felt, and compare this to enjoying being in a sauna or steam bath. Think of examples like this from your own life that indicate how the mind shapes our experience and informs how we relate to external circumstances.

²⁶ Practice each of these steps in succession, making each the focal point of your nature of mind practice for a number of sessions before moving on to the next set of instructions.

- **Step four** is to contemplate how samsara is perpetuated by the mind. Out of ignorance, the *kleshas* (anger, attachment, pride, jealousy etc.) are produced. These lead us to engage in negative actions that create negative karma, which in turn results in samsara, the cycle of suffering and dissatisfaction. Contemplate how all of samsara begins with the mind and is perpetuated by the ignorance of not recognizing our true nature and instead seeing things in a distorted way.
- **Step five** is to consider how all phenomena are created by the mind. Look at an object and imagine breaking it down further and further. Do you reach a point where you cannot break these parts, or particles, down any further? If you think you have found the smallest particle that constitutes the object, ask yourself, “Does this particle have sides or not?” If the answer is “Yes, the particle has sides,” the consequence of that answer is that the object can be broken down further, because something that has sides can always be broken down further. If the answer is “No, the particle does not have sides,” the consequence is that the object in front of you could not be there, because something that does not have sides cannot connect with other particles to build something bigger. Particles with no sides would simply merge with one another. Continue to investigate in this way, and try to recognize how the apparent solidity of things is illusory, like a mirage or a dream. Notice how everything that appears is empty and not true or real in the way that it appears. You can also contemplate how periods of time can be broken down, or how everything we experience in our dreams appear to be real, but are creations of the mind. As you contemplate these topics, pause from time to time and rest in awareness.
- **Step six** is connected with resting meditation. Begin by turning the mind inward and be aware of the feeling of “me.” At this point, you do not have to ask any questions or contemplate; just be aware of the feeling of “me” or “self.” Where is this “me” located? What is it like? As you try to do this, you might find that you cannot really pinpoint this so-called “me.” Simply notice what happens when you observe the feeling of being a self. You can also observe other experiences. Look at an object in front of you, for instance. Are you experiencing the object as it truly is? Is it “out

there” just as it appears, or is it a projection of your mind? Notice how everything you experience is like a dream: there is nothing there, yet it appears. Simply recognize this and then let go and rest within this knowing.

- Throughout this exploration, the main practice is still to rest in awareness. You can intersperse periods of resting in awareness with a brief inquiry. For instance, you might begin by resting in awareness and then gently observe your experience of body, speech, and mind for a few moments, and then rest again in awareness. In this way, you can alternate brief, gentle periods of inquiry with periods of resting naturally in awareness.
- End your nature of mind practice by resting in awareness.

~ Optional Readings ~

In addition to engaging the material in the ngöndro course in Vajrayana Online, or for those who are using this guide as their primary source for instructions, what follows are a few suggestions for optional readings from contemporary and traditional texts of the Kagyu and Nyingma traditions on the topics for this level.

Optional Readings for Phase 1:

The Four Thoughts

- The precious human life (*TCiC*²⁷: 71–92; *Words*²⁸: 19–38; *Guide*²⁹: 39–54; *Torch*³⁰: 5–10)
- Impermanence (*TCiC*: 93–112; *Words*: 39–60; *Guide*: 55–61; *Torch*: 11–14)
- Karma (*TCiC*: 113–130; *Words*: 101–132; *Guide*: 67–86; *Torch*: 14–20)
- The defects of samsara (*TCiC*: 131–159; *Words*: 61–100; *Guide*: 62–66; *Torch*: 21–27)

Stillness, Movement, and Awareness

- [*Pointing Out the Dharmakaya*](#),³¹ pp. 32–34, pp. 36–39 and pp. 40–43 (sessions 17–18, 21–23, and 26)
- *Clarifying the Natural State*,³² pp. 36–37, pp. 65–66, and pp. 72–73
- *Moonbeams of Mahamudra*,³³ pp. 247–250

Optional Readings on Refuge

- *TCiC*: 163–206; *Words*: 170–192; *Guide*: 93–133; *Torch*: 31–36

²⁷ *Turning Confusion into Clarity* by Mingyur Rinpoche

²⁸ *Words of My Perfect Teacher* by Patrul Rinpoche

²⁹ *A Guide to the Words of My Perfect Teacher* by Khenpo Ngawang Pelzang

³⁰ *The Torch of True Meaning* by Jamgon Kongtrul

³¹ By Karmapa IX Wangchuk Dorje

³² By Dakpo Tashi Namgyal

³³ By Dakpo Tashi Namgyal (Translator, Elizabeth M. Callahan)

Optional Readings for Phase 2:

Bodhichitta

- The four immeasurables
 - Immeasurable love (*TCiC: 207–219; Words: 198–201; Guide: 145–147*)
 - Immeasurable compassion (*TCiC: 219; Words: 201–212; Guide: 148–150*)
 - Immeasurable joy (*TCiC: 219; Words: 213–218; Guide: 150–151*)
 - Immeasurable equanimity (*TCiC: 219–220; Words: 196–198; Guide: 137–145*)
- The essence and types of bodhichitta (*TCiC: 220–228; Words: 218–219; Guide: 151–155; Torch: 37–45*)
- Considering others equal to oneself (*Words: 222–223; Guide: 165–168*)
- Exchanging self and others (*Words: 223–228; Guide: 169–177*)
- Considering others more important than oneself (*Words: 228–234; Guide: 177–181*)
- The six paramitas (*TCiC: 221–224*)
 - Generosity (*Words: 234–238; Guide: 184–187*)
 - Ethical conduct (*Words: 238–240; Guide: 187–192*)
 - Patience (*Words: 240–245; Guide: 192–193*)
 - Joyful effort (*Words: 245–248; Guide: 193–196*)
 - Concentration (*Words: 248–251; Guide: 196–204*)
 - Wisdom (*Words: 251–262; Guide: 204–219*)

All Phenomena Come from Mind

- [*Pointing Out the Dharmakaya*](#), pp. 34–35 and pp. 39 (sessions 19 and 24)
- *Clarifying the Natural State*, pp. 32–35, and pp. 43–45
- *Moonbeams of Mahamudra*, pp. 233–242 and 245–247

~ *Sample Retreat Schedules* ~

6 hour schedule

6:15 – 7:15 First session
7:15 – 9:30 Breakfast and break
9:30 – 11:00 Second session
11:00 – 2:00 Lunch and break
2:00 – 3:00 Third session
3:00 – 4:30 Break
4:30 – 6:00 Fourth session
6:00 – 7:30 Dinner
7:30 – 8:30 Fifth session

8 hour schedule

6:15 – 7:45 First session
7:45 – 9:30 Breakfast and break
9:30 – 11:30 Second session
11:30 – 1:30 Lunch and break
1:30 – 3:00 Third session
3:00 – 4:30 Break
4:30 – 6:00 Fourth session
6:00 – 7:30 Dinner
7:30 – 9:00 Fifth session

10 hour schedule

6:15 – 7:45 First session
7:45 – 9:00 Breakfast and break
9:00 – 11:30 Second session
11:30 – 1:30 Lunch and break
1:30 – 3:00 Third session
3:00 – 3:45 Break
3:45 – 6:00 Fourth session
6:00 – 7:15 Dinner
7:15 – 9:30 Fifth session

These schedules can be used for any length of retreat. They can also be used for any type of retreat, whether it is a *Joy of Living* retreat, nature of mind retreat, ngöndro or *Nectar of the Path* retreat, or a sadhana retreat.

~ Contact Us ~

If you have feedback and/or suggestions with regards to this guide or the accompanying courses online, or simply wish to get in touch with us, please email the program development team at: programdevteam@tergar.org